Talk early. Talk often.

Young people are more likely to stay nicotine-free when a trusted adult talks with them openly and often. This guide gives parents, caregivers, coaches and mentors the facts, the signs to watch for, and the words to start that conversation.

~95%
of U.S. middle and high schoolers don't vape. Most kids are making the healthy choice.

1 in 3
teens who vape now do it every day, a sign of real nicotine dependence.

2×
Youth use of nicotine pouches has doubled since 2021, even as vaping declined.

Source: 2025 National Youth Tobacco Survey (FDA & CDC); analysis published in *Pediatrics*, 2026.

What every adult should know

Teen brains are still wiring. The brain develops until about age 25. Nicotine can affect attention, learning and mood, and makes addiction more likely.

Devices are easy to hide. Vapes can look like USB drives, pens, highlighters or phone gear.

Flavors are the hook. Most young users choose fruit, candy or mint flavors.

Labels can mislead. "Nicotine-free" products have been found to contain nicotine, and some vapes hold THC.

Pouches are the new trend. Tucked under the lip, they leave no smell or vapor.

Signs worth noticing

One sign alone proves nothing. Look for patterns, and ask before you assume.

- A sweet or fruity scent with no obvious source
- Unfamiliar small devices, pods, chargers or round pouch tins
- More thirst or dry mouth than usual
- Irritability or restlessness that eases after time alone
- Trouble focusing, or dropping activities they used to enjoy
- Unexplained spending or new requests for cash

Turn over for conversation starters and free quit support →

Starting the conversation

You don't need every answer. You just need to keep talking.

Tips that help it land

1. **Pick a natural moment.** Car rides, a vape shop you pass or an ad make easy openings.
2. **Ask first, then listen.** Learn what they see and think before you share your view.
3. **Stay calm and curious.** Questions keep the talk going; lectures and scare tactics end it.
4. **Be clear about expectations.** Say plainly that you want them nicotine-free, and why.
5. **Keep the door open.** Check in again, and model the choices you ask of them.

Conversation starters

"What have you noticed about vaping at school?"

"Why do you think some kids start?"

"What would you say if a friend offered you one?"

"What do vape companies want kids to believe?"

Practice an exit line together

"Nah, I'm good."

"Can't, I've got practice."

"My parents would ground me forever."

Let them know it's always okay to blame you.

If you learn your child is vaping

Pause before you react. Anger makes hiding more likely.

Ask what it does for them. Stress relief and fitting in need different answers.

Treat it as a health issue. Cravings and irritability signal dependence, not just defiance.

Plan the quit together, and bring in their pediatrician or school counselor.

Free help & resources

Text DITCHVAPE to 88709

This is Quitting (Truth Initiative): free, anonymous text support, ages 13–24.

Call 1-800-QUIT-NOW

Free state quitline coaching, for adults too.

FOR PARENTS

Parents Against Vaping E-cigarettes

Parent guides, quit support, ways to get involved
parentsagainstvaping.org/parents-accordion

Campaign for Tobacco-Free Kids

Facts and research on youth vaping and tobacco
tobaccofreekids.org